Helping a Struggling Learner

My classroom process: from noticing to support, and telling a language need from a learning disability

Spencer Bowen · 7th grade math and science
Palm River Academy, Hội An, Vietnam

what I do · language or learning disability? · contact with the family · wellbeing support · PRA leadership · decision · Underlined text links to a resource.

THE MAIN PATH

I notice a student is struggling

Signs I watch for

- Gets the calculation right, the word problem wrong
- Work often unfinished
- Avoids reading aloud or writing an explanation
- Little progress on checks over several weeks
- Quiet, withdrawn or upset, or a change in behavior
- Missing lessons

? What kind of concern is it?
wellbeing goes left · learning stays here

wellbeing →

academic ↓

STEP 1 · 2–3 WEEKS

Watch and keep a record

Short notes, work samples, quiz and whiteboard results. Is it every topic, or only word problems? Only in English, or in the math too?

STEP 2

Change what I do in class first

Teach the key words on purpose, read the question aloud with the class, use the Vietnamese side of my **bilingual slides**, check in with the student during the work, and sit them where I can see their page.

Teach academic vocabulary over several days; build oral and written English into content lessons (**Baker et al., 2014**, Recs. 1–2)

? Better after 3–4 weeks?

YES

Keep the changes. Share the progress in the family notebook.

NO ↓

FAMILY · STAGE 2

Email or Zalo, whichever the family uses, to ask about the student's history (questions below).

Step 3 · Language need or learning disability?

1. Compare with true peers
Do other students with the same language background and years in English struggle the same way? If most do, it's probably language.
Medina, 2018

2. Take the English out
Give the same math as bare numbers, or with the Vietnamese key word. If they can do it then, the barrier is the English, not the math.
my own classroom check

3. Ask about Vietnamese
From the family: any delay learning to talk, how they read and write in Vietnamese, past schooling, attendance, hearing and eyesight, and whether reading was hard for others in the family.
Spear-Swerling, 2006

4. Rule out missed learning
Gaps in schooling, many absences, or never having been taught the topic can look like a disability. These have to be ruled out first.
Medina, 2018

Being multilingual is not a disorder (**ASHA**). A learning disability shows up in the home language too, and stays even after good support designed for English learners (**Spear-Swerling, 2006**).

? Where do the signs point?

MOSTLY LANGUAGE

Language support plan

Key words with pictures and examples, speaking practice in full sentences, Vietnamese beside the English, and the question read together. Review in 4–6 weeks.

No progress? Then take it to the head teachers →

BEYOND LANGUAGE

Step 4 · Bring my notes to Mr. Seth and Mr. David

Our head teacher and deputy head teacher. I bring the record from steps 1–3: what I saw, what I tried, and what the family told me.

FAMILY · STAGE 3

Meet the family face to face

With Mr. Seth and Mr. David. We share what we've seen, listen to the parents, and agree on next steps together, with translation if the family needs it.

Families should be part of the team and know their rights (**Medina, 2018**)

STEP 5

A support plan with clear goals

Small-group or one-to-one help, with Mr. David as support specialist, plus any further steps PRA and the family agree on. The research recommends intensive help for struggling readers from trained specialists (**Kamil et al., 2008**, Rec. 5).

STEP 6

Review and keep the family in the loop

I check progress against the goals every few weeks, adjust, and keep the family updated through all three channels.

IF IT'S WELLBEING

EMOTIONAL OR OTHER CONCERN

I step in first

A quiet check-in with the student, away from the class. I listen, and I don't push for details.

Extra support from Mr. David

Mr. David has a psychology background and serves as our support specialist when needed. If the student would be more comfortable with a woman, Ms. Kiu, who also has a psychology background, takes that role.

FAMILY

Mr. David and I decide how to reach the family

For a wellbeing concern this is a personal contact, not a note in the family notebook. We agree what to say and who says it.

Keep watching

If the student's learning is affected too, I also follow the academic path in the middle.

Also at PRA: a wellbeing class

Students also have a wellbeing class, alongside this one-to-one support.

Wellbeing comes first. A student who is upset or anxious can look like a student who can't do the work.

TALKING WITH FAMILIES

THREE WAYS I REACH PARENTS

Family notebook	messages I write home
Email	for parents who prefer email
Zalo Vietnamese messaging app	for parents who prefer Zalo

STAGE 1 · WITH STEP 2

A note in the family notebook

What I've noticed, what I'm trying in class, and one small thing they can do at home. Low-key, so nobody panics.

STAGE 2 · WITH STEP 3

Email or Zalo with questions

I ask about the student's history and how they do in Vietnamese, and offer a call if it's easier to talk.

STAGE 3 · WITH STEP 4

Face-to-face meeting

With Mr. Seth and Mr. David, once the signs point beyond language or the language plan hasn't worked.

ALL THE WAY THROUGH

Good news too

A quick Zalo or notebook message when something goes well, and my Friday update with the week's lessons. Parents shouldn't only hear from me when there's a problem.

MATH AT HOME

What I suggest to families

- Play math games and puzzles together; anything with dice helps number sense.
- When an answer is wrong, look for the logic in it instead of just saying "wrong."
- Don't rush them or drill for speed.
- Never say "I was bad at math."
- Praise the learning and the effort, not "you're smart."
- Ask your child to teach you the week's key words, in English and Vietnamese.
- Open the **lesson slides** together; most have a Vietnamese version.

First five from **Boaler, n.d.**; last two are mine

References

American Speech-Language-Hearing Association. (n.d.). *Multilingual service delivery* [Practice portal]. https://www.asha.org/practice-portal/professional-issues/multilingual-service-delivery/

Baker, S., Lesaux, N., Jayanthi, M., Dimino, J., Proctor, C. P., Morris, J., Gersten, R., Haymond, K., Kieffer, M. J., Linan-Thompson, S., & Newman-Gonchar, R. (2014). *Teaching academic content and literacy to English learners in elementary and middle school* (NCEE 2014-4012). Institute of Education Sciences, U.S. Department of Education. https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/Docs/PracticeGuide/english_learners_pg_040114.pdf

Boaler, J. (n.d.). *Advice for parents* [Handout]. youcubed, Stanford University. https://www.youcubed.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/09/Parent-Night-Handout-2025.pdf

Kamil, M. L., Borman, G. D., Dole, J., Kral, C. C., Salinger, T., & Torgesen, J. (2008). *Improving adolescent literacy: Effective classroom and intervention practices* (NCEE 2008-4027). Institute of Education Sciences, U.S. Department of Education. https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/Docs/PracticeGuide/adlit_pg_082608.pdf

Medina, T. J. (2018). *Language difference or language disorder? ELs and special education* (Exploring Equity Issues). Mid-Atlantic Equity Consortium. https://maec.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/Exploring-Equity-Language-Difference-or-Language-Disorder.pdf

Spear-Swerling, L. (2006). *Learning disabilities in English language learners*. Colorín Colorado. https://www.colorincolorado.org/article/learning-disabilities-english-language-learners

AI use: Claude Code was used as a general tool in the formatting of this document.